Tzav 5784

This week is פרשת צו and also פרשת פרה. We are learning today as a זכות for אחינו כל בית ישראל, particularly the members of the IDF, whose lives are put on the line and in harm's way as they strive to help כלל ישראל and rid us of our enemies. We are also celebrating the אופרוף of the newest member of our family, the honorable R' Chaim Mandel. We embrace and welcome him with open arms into our ever-growing and ever-improving family. Additionally, the יארצייט of my טהרה מאמא תמר רייזל בת מרדכי צבי ע"ה is approaching in the next week or two, and בעזרת השם, this learning should be an עליה for her נשמה.

פרשת צו, which continues to discuss more details of the קרבנות begun in פרשת ויקרא, is connected to פרשת פרה, which deals with the פרה אדומה. Although the פרה אדומה is not a קרבן, many of its הלכות are similar to those of the קרבנות. פרשת פרה, which we read at the end of our regular leining, has a fascinating רש"י on the words פָּרָה אֲדֻמָּה. Rabbi Oelbaum, in his חומש שיעור pointed out this רש"י, I'll read it to you from פרשת חקת: מָשָׁל לְבֶן שִׁפְחָה שֶׁטִּנֵּף פָּלָטִין שֶׁל מֶלֶךְ - A servant woman brought her baby to the king's palace and the baby made a mess; אָמְרוּ תָּבֹא אִמּוֹ וּתְקַנְּחַ הַצוֹאָה - Let his mother come and clean up the mess; כָּךְ תָּבֹא פָּרָה וּתְכַפֵּר עַל הָעֶגֶל - so too the פרה אדומה comes to be מכפר the חטא of the עגל, the greatest חטא in history, which we had in פרשת כי תשא just a few weeks ago.

Rabbi Oelbaum cited the טעם ודעת from R' Moshe Sternbuch, who quoted Rav Itzele Peterburger. What is the connection between the פרה אדומה and the משל that רש"י brings about the baby who soils the king's palace, requiring his mother to come clean it up? Another item which Rabbi Oelbaum alluded to is the unpleasant experience of a child's dirty diaper. What purpose could there possibly be for such an occurrence?

He brings a beautiful explanation, based on a פסוק in ישעיהו (ד׳:ד׳): אִם רָחַץ ה׳ אֶת צֹאַת בְּנוֹת צִיּוֹן. What does this mean? When a baby soils himself, most people are repulsed. They step away, wrinkle their noses, and say, "Ugh, that stinks! Take him away!" The entire world finds the situation disgusting and unpleasant. But there is one person who rushes to take care of the baby, who embraces the responsibility with love and care - his mother. The mother does not recoil; instead, she runs to clean him up, comfort him, and make him feel better. She does this out of pure love, knowing that her care will help him. This, says the נביא, is our relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא. The חטא העגל was a horrifying עבירה - an act of spiritual defilement committed right there at הר סיני. Who could possibly cleanse such a stain? Only הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself. And how does He do it? Through the פרה אדומה. Just as a mother lovingly cleans her child despite the mess, הקדוש ברוך הוא, in His infinite love for כלל ישראל, provides us with the means to cleanse ourselves. The פרה אדומה represents this divine compassion and the constant opportunity for כפרה, no matter how severe the חטא.

This concept also teaches us a profound lesson about the great endeavor known as family. We live in a time when family values are under attack from all directions, across all societies and cultures. The world seeks to undermine the very foundation of the family unit. But we in כלל ישראל cherish and revere the concept of family. We uphold it as one of the greatest gifts that הקדוש ברוך הוא has given us. We recognize how wrong the world is and how right הקדוש ברוך הוא is in granting us the privilege of building families, raising children, and experiencing true נחת. It is in this spirit of joy and gratitude that we welcome the newest member of our family. We are thrilled to embrace him and look forward to his vibrant role in our ever-growing family.

Im Yirtzeh Hashem, may our family continue to grow both in כמות and איכות, ever stronger in our עבודת השם and our dedication to כלל ישראל.

https://youtu.be/ewQwdykPGxs